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CAT BURGLARS

A tabletop roleplaying game of street cats, sticky paws and getting away with it

They saw it go in. They're getting it out.

VERSION 0.5 · DRAFT

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A tabletop roleplaying game of street cats, sticky paws and getting away with it

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TYPEFACES

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PLAY IT ONLINE

A companion game system for Foundry Virtual Tabletop

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PART ONE

The Gang

Who you are, how you play, and the cats you'll play.

part-gang



CHAPTER 1

Welcome to the Street

"She had a chicken. A whole chicken. In a bag. And she went in and shut the door." — Pip, age nine months

You are a gang of street cats. You live behind the bins, under the cars and on the warm roofs of the bakery. Tonight one of you saw a human carry something into a house: something **delicious**, something **fun**, or **a box**. Now the whole gang wants it. You'll get it at all costs — without getting caught.

Cat Burglars is a tabletop roleplaying game for **3 to 5 players** and one **Storyteller**, for ages 8 and up. Each player is one cat in the gang. The Storyteller plays the house: the humans who live there, their pets, and the prize that is about to be eaten, played with or put away. One robbery takes about one to two hours.

What you need

- **Six-sided dice** — about ten for the table. A roll never uses more than five.
- An **eight-sided die** (d8) for making cats. No d8? Roll a d6 twice and use the table's note.
- A **cat sheet** for each player and the **house tracker** for the Storyteller (both at the back of this book), and pencils.
- A handful of **tokens** (coins, buttons, cat treats) for Cattitude.
- The house you'll rob. Part Four has five ready to play.

How a robbery goes

1. **Make your cats** (Chapter 2), or pick from the ready-made gang (Chapter 3).
2. **The human goes in.** The Storyteller reads the start of the house: who lives there, and what the human just carried inside.
3. **Pick your ways in.** Every house has several entrances — a cat flap, a window left open, the gap behind the human's legs. Cats can split up.
4. **Play in rounds.** In each round every cat gets one Move and one Action. Then the house moves: the humans wander, the dog sniffs about, and the **Prize Clock** ticks.
5. **Get it, and get out.** The prize must end up eaten or outside, and every cat must end up outside too.
6. **Find out how it went:** a **Clean Getaway**, a **Messy Getaway**, or **Busted**.

THE WHOLE GAME ON ONE HAND

To do something tricky, roll some six-sided dice and look at the highest one. A 6 means it works. A 4 or 5 means it works, but you made a noise. A 1, 2 or 3 means it didn't work, and you made a noise. Two 6s is **Purrfect**.

Being seen isn't being caught. Being seen doing something is. Every time a human sees you do something, their mood fills up — towards the **Broom** if you're naughty, towards a **Cuddle** if you're sweet. Fill one all the way and a cat gets chased out or scooped up.

Nobody gets hurt

This is a cartoon. Cats always land on their feet, dogs only ever bark and chase, and the broom only ever sweeps a cat out of the door. The worst thing that can happen to a cat in this game is that a human loves it so much they keep it — and it has to live in a warm house with a full food bowl for ever. The gang will miss it terribly.

FOR THE STORYTELLER

Part Two is the rules, Part Three is how to run them, and Part Four is five houses ready to play. Read Chapter 11 before your first robbery; it has a checklist for every round.

Words to know

WORD	WHAT IT MEANS
Approach	How your cat does something: **Sneaky**, **Sweet**, **Savage** or **Streetwise**. Each has a rating of 1 to 4.
Instinct	Something your cat can't help doing, like knocking things off tables. It helps you — and tempts you.
Cattitude	Your cat's swagger, kept as tokens. Spend it for an extra die, a reroll, or to resist a temptation.
The Mood	How the household feels about the cats: two meters, **Broom** and **Cuddle**.
Patience	How full a Mood meter can get before something happens.
Prize Clock	How many rounds until the prize is eaten, put away or thrown out.
Round	Every cat takes a turn, then the house does.
Storyteller	The player who runs the house and everyone in it.

EXAMPLE OF PLAY

Storyteller: "Mr Pell puts the chicken on the kitchen counter and goes to hang up his coat. The kitchen window is open a crack above the sink."

Tilly's player: "Two-Bin Tilly hops up the bins and squeezes through the window. Sneaky!" Tilly has Sneaky 2, and climbing is her Knack (she's a Climber), but the window is Tricky: 2 + 1 − 1 = 2 dice. She rolls 4 and 6. A 6 is Clean: she's in, and nobody saw.

Big Biscuit's player: "Biscuit goes through the cat flap. It clacks." No roll, but the cat flap makes noise. At the end of the round, Mr Pell wanders into the utility room to see what that was…

ch-your-cat

CHAPTER 2

Making Your Cat

Every cat in the gang is a stray with a name the street gave it, a coat, a few scars, and a way of doing things. Making one takes about five minutes. Pick from each table, or roll for it — or roll and keep what makes you laugh.

SEVEN STEPS

1. A street name.
2. A coat, a mark, and eyes.
3. Your approaches: **3, 2, 1, 1**.
4. Two instincts.
5. A body: Lean or Chonky.
6. A quirk.
7. Cattitude **2** and **9 Lives**.

1. A street name

Roll a d6 on each column, or pick. Two-Bin Tilly got her name from the two bins she sleeps between.

D6	FIRST BIT	NAME
1	Alley	Tilly
2	Two-Bin	Joe
3	Gutter	Pearl
4	Lucky	Mags
5	Midnight	Dot
6	Lamppost	Sully

2. A coat, a mark, and eyes

These are for the story and for drawing your cat; they don't change the rules.

ROLL	COAT (D8)	MARK (D6)	EYES (D6)
1	Black	A notch in one ear	Green
2	Grey tabby	One white sock	Green
3	Ginger tabby	A kink at the tip of the tail	Amber
4	Brown tabby	A white star on the chest	Amber
5	Black and white	An old collar, too big	Blue
6	Calico	One crooked whisker	One of each
7	Tortoiseshell	—	—
8	Cream	—	—

No d8? Roll a d6 until it shows 1–4. Then roll it once more: on a 1–3 keep the first number, on a 4–6 add 4 to it. That gives 1 to 8, all equally likely.

3. Your approaches

Every cat does things in four ways. Give your cat the ratings **3, 2, 1 and 1**, one to each approach, in any order. A rating is how many dice you roll when you do something that way.

APPROACH	WHEN YOU USE IT	THE GANG CALLS YOU…
Sneaky	Doing things without being noticed: hiding, slipping past, creeping, snatching something from under a nose.	the Shadow
Sweet	Charming humans and soft pets: rubbing round legs, purring, the slow blink, begging, being let in and out.	the Charmer
Savage	Force and speed: hissing, swatting, shoving, bolting, facing down a dog, wriggling free.	the Muscle
Streetwise	Knowing how things work: door handles, latches, cupboards, bags, the shortcut over the shed.	the Brains

Your 3 is your role in the gang. A gang works best with a bit of everything, but it's your cat.

To roll instead, roll a d6 for the approach that gets the 3: 1 Sneaky, 2 Sweet, 3 Savage, 4 Streetwise, 5–6 your choice. Roll again for the 2, rerolling an approach you already have. The other two get 1.

4. Two instincts

Roll a d8 twice, rerolling if you get the same one twice, or pick two. Each instinct gives you a **Knack** — an extra die when what you're doing suits it — and a **temptation**, something you find very hard to walk past. Chapter 7 says exactly what each one does.

D8	INSTINCT	KNACK: +1 DIE TO…	CAN'T RESIST…
1	Curious	open, search and figure things out	an open bag, drawer or box of something new
2	Knocker	knock, push and topple things	a thing near the edge of a table
3	Box Sitter	hide	a box, a bag, a basket
4	Hunter	pounce, chase and fight	anything that moves
5	Lap Cat	charm a human	a warm lap, a sunny spot, a hand offering a stroke
6	Foodie	find, steal and eat food	food that isn't the prize
7	Climber	climb, jump and balance	somewhere high up
8	Scrapper	face down and fight animals	an animal that hisses, barks or stares

No d8? Use the same trick as for coats: roll a d6 until it shows 1–4, then roll once more and add 4 on a 4–6.

5. A body

Roll a d6 or pick: **1–3 Lean**, **4–6 Chonky**.

- **Lean** cats fit through **Tight** gaps: a cracked window, a gap under a gate. They can carry Small things.
- **Chonky** cats can't fit through Tight gaps, but they can carry a **Medium** thing on their own, and they get **+1 die to wriggle free** when a human picks them up. There's a lot of them to hold.

6. A quirk

Roll a d6 or make one up. Quirks are for fun; they never change the rules.

D6	QUIRK
1	Hates the rain more than anything in the world.
2	Collects bottle caps under the bakery steps.
3	Was somebody's pet, once. Doesn't talk about it.
4	Never forgets a face, especially a face with a broom.
5	Sleeps on the warm roof of the launderette.
6	Talks to pigeons. The pigeons don't talk back.

7. Cattitude and Lives

Every cat starts each robbery with **2 Cattitude** (take two tokens). You can hold up to **5**. You earn it by giving in to your instincts and by rolling Purrfects, and you spend it to do better (Chapter 4). Spend it — it doesn't carry over to the next robbery.

Every cat has **9 Lives**. They only matter in a campaign (Chapter 13): when a cat gets adopted, a Life lets it slip out of its new home and back to the gang.

The gang

Give your gang a name. Roll a d6 or pick: 1 the Bin Lid Gang, 2 the Lamppost Lot, 3 the Back Alley Seven (however many you are), 4 the Midnight Moggies, 5 the Puddle Street Paws, 6 the Fish Shop Crew.

EXAMPLE: MAKING MARMALADE MAGS

Lena rolls a 4 and a 4: **Lucky Mags**. She likes "Marmalade Mags" better, so that's her name. She rolls a ginger tabby coat, a kinked tail and green eyes. She puts her 3 in Sneaky and her 2 in Savage. She rolls a 3 and a 4 on the d8: **Box Sitter** and **Hunter**. She rolls a 2 for her body: **Lean**. Her quirk is a 5: she sleeps on the launderette roof. She takes 2 Cattitude tokens and writes 9 Lives.

ch-gang

CHAPTER 3

The Ready-Made Gang

No time to make cats? Meet the Bin Lid Gang. Pick one each and start robbing. With three players, leave out Pip and one other; with four, leave out Pip.

Two-Bin Tilly



"Every lid on this street has a trick. I know all of them."

A grey tabby with green eyes and a red collar she got from nobody knows where, with a brass tag that says nothing at all. She's the Brains: she knows how doors open, which bins are full on Tuesdays, and the way over every fence.

Streetwise 3 · **Sneaky** 2 · **Sweet** 1 · **Savage** 1

Instincts Curious, Climber · **Body** Lean · **Quirk** never forgets a face

Big Biscuit



"Excuse me. I'm coming through. Thank you."

A big brown tabby with a cream muzzle, amber eyes and a notch in his left ear that he got from a fox, or a fence, depending on who's asking. He's the Muscle. Dogs think twice about him. So does the gang, when there's only one sardine left.

Savage 3 · **Streetwise** 2 · **Sweet** 1 · **Sneaky** 1

Instincts Scrapper, Foodie · **Body** Chonky · **Quirk** sleeps on the launderette roof

Velvet



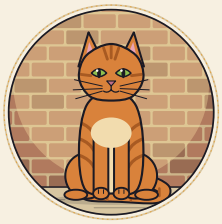
"Hello. Yes. It's me. I know."

A sleek black cat with amber eyes, a white star on her chest and one white sock on her left forepaw. She's the Charmer: one slow blink and a grown-up forgets what they came into the room for. She was somebody's pet once. She doesn't talk about it.

Sweet 3 · **Sneaky** 2 · **Savage** 1 · **Streetwise** 1

Instincts Lap Cat, Knocker · **Body** Lean · **Quirk** was somebody's pet

Marmalade Mags



"..."

A ginger tabby with green eyes and a kink at the very tip of her tail. She's the Shadow. You won't see her come in, and you won't see her leave, and the chicken will be gone. If there's a box anywhere in the house, that's where she is.

Sneaky 3 · **Savage** 2 · **Streetwise** 1 · **Sweet** 1

Instincts Box Sitter, Hunter · **Body** Lean · **Quirk** hates the rain

Pip



"Is that a string? Is that a STRING?"

The gang's kitten: a fluffy white calico with a ginger patch over her left eye, a black right ear, black spots and a black tail

tip, and big blue eyes. Humans melt. Then she knocks their tea over. She's small enough to squeeze through anything.

Sweet 3 · **Savage** 2 · **Sneaky** 1 · **Streetwise** 1

Instincts Hunter, Curious · **Body** Lean · **Quirk** talks to pigeons

PART TWO

The Robbery

How to roll, how the house feels about you, and what happens when it's had enough.

part-robbery

ch-rolling

CHAPTER 4

Rolling the Dice

Most of the time a cat just does things: walks into the hall, sniffs the doormat, sits on the stairs. You only roll when something could go wrong — a climb, a latch, a dog, or anything a human might see.

When to roll

- When the house says a thing needs a roll: a high counter, a stiff door, a microchip cat flap.
- When you deal with a pet in your way.
- When you charm a human (that's always a Sweet roll).
- When **a human can see you** and you do anything but walk, sit or wash (Chapter 5).

How many dice

Say what your cat does and how — Sneaky, Sweet, Savage or Streetwise — and the Storyteller tells you if it's plain, **Tricky** or **Hard**. Then count your dice:

COUNTING DICE

1. Start with your **approach** rating (1–4).
2. **+1** if one of your instincts suits what you're doing (your **Knack**; never more than +1).
3. **+1 for each cat helping** (at most +2). A helper is in the same room, uses its Action, and doesn't roll.
4. **+1** if you spend a **Cattitude** token.
5. You can never have more than **5 dice**.
6. Now take dice away: **Tricky –1**, **Hard –2**; a pet in your way takes its rating; and on a **Sneaky** or **Sweet** roll, a watching human takes their **Attention** (only the highest, if several are watching).

If that leaves you with **0 or fewer**, you can still try: roll **two** dice and keep the **lower** one. It can't be better than a Scrape.

Reading the dice

Roll your dice together and look at the **highest** one.

HIGHEST DIE	RESULT	WHAT HAPPENS
1, 2 or 3	Flop	It doesn't work, and you made a noise.
4 or 5	Scrape	It works, but you made a noise.
6	Clean	It works, quietly.
Two or more 6s	Purrfect	It works so smoothly that nobody minds: no Mood step, and you gain 1 Cattitude.

Noise brings humans to look (Chapter 6). A Flop means you can try again later, but not this round.

Push your luck

Once per roll, after you see the dice, you can **Push**: pick up every die that isn't a 6 and roll them again. Then read the dice again. Pay for it with **1 Cattitude**, or by adding **1 step** to the Mood meter that roll would fill (Chapter 5) — even if nobody saw. That's what "at all costs" means: there is always a way to try harder, and it always costs something.

Cattitude

Every cat starts each robbery with **2 Cattitude** and can hold up to **5**. Anything left at the end is lost, so spend it.

GAIN 1 CATTITUDE WHEN YOU…	SPEND 1 CATTITUDE TO…
give in to a temptation (Chapter 7)	add a die before you roll
roll a Purrfect	Push after you roll
	resist a temptation

Doing it together

When the whole gang does the same thing at once — dragging the box, squeezing through the same window — one cat leads and rolls; up to two others help (+1 die each). The result counts for all of them, and the Mood moves once.

EXAMPLE

Big Biscuit wants to drive the Okafors' dog out of the kitchen. That's Savage (3), and he's a Scrapper, so +1: 4 dice. The dog's rating is 2, so 4 − 2 = 2 dice. He rolls 3 and 2 — a Flop. He Pushes for 1 Cattitude and rerolls both: 6 and 1. A 6: Clean. The dog runs to hide behind the sofa.

HOW LIKELY IS IT?

DICE	IT WORKS	CLEAN OR BETTER	PURRFECT
0 (keep the lower of 2)	1 in 4	never	never
1	1 in 2	1 in 6	never
2	3 in 4	1 in 3	1 in 36
3	7 in 8	2 in 5	1 in 14
4	15 in 16	1 in 2	1 in 8
5	31 in 32	3 in 5	1 in 5

ch-mood

CHAPTER 5

Seen, and the Mood

"Oh, hello! Whose cat are you? … Is that my chicken?"

A SPIDER IN YOUR KITCHEN IS A PROBLEM. A CAT IN your kitchen is just a cat. Humans don't mind cats wandering about — until a cat does something. That is the heart of this game: **being seen isn't being caught. Being seen doing something is.**

Who sees you

You are **seen** when you are in the same room as a human who is awake, isn't Distracted, and isn't busy holding a cat — and you aren't in a hiding spot. Humans never see into the next room. Pets see too, but they don't fill the Mood: the dog has its own ways of making trouble (Chapter 10).

Hiding spots. Every room has somewhere to hide — under the sofa, behind the curtain, on top of the wardrobe — unless the house says it hasn't. Getting into one is a simple Action if nobody sees you, or a Sneaky roll if somebody does. You stay hidden until you move or do anything else.

Doing things in view

Walking, sitting, washing and staring are free, even right under a human's nose. **Anything else you do while seen is a roll**, even things that are usually simple, like picking something up or eating a portion. Choose how:

- **Sneaky** — do it without them noticing. Their Attention takes dice away, but a Clean Sneaky roll adds nothing to the Mood.
- **Savage** — just do it, fast. Their Attention doesn't matter, but they'll notice.
- **Sweet** — if what you're doing is charming them.

The Mood

The house has one **Mood** with two meters, kept on the house tracker. Each meter fills up to the house's **Patience** (usually 3 to 6).

- **Broom** fills when humans see cats being naughty. When it's full, out comes the broom.
- **Cuddle** fills when humans see cats being sweet. When it's full, somebody gets picked up.

MOOD STEPS

When a human sees your roll:

- **Clean or Scrape:** 1 step. **Sweet** rolls fill **Cuddle**; Sneaky, Savage and Streetwise rolls fill **Broom**. A **Sneaky Clean** adds nothing — they never noticed.
- **Purrfect:** nothing.
- **Flop:** 2 steps on whichever meter is **fuller** (its own meter if they're level). A flop makes their mood worse: if they're already cross they get crosser, and if they're already soppy they want to pick you up.
- A kid who sees the roll — even a roll aimed at that kid — **doubles** Cuddle steps from it.
- One roll changes the Mood once, however many humans saw it.

Some things add steps without a roll: **+1 Broom** when a human comes to see a noise you made on purpose and finds the mess, and **+1 Broom** each time a human walks into the prize's room and finds it disturbed — a step done, a portion gone, or the prize not where they left it.

Shoo!

When **Broom** fills, the human who saw it (the one with the highest Attention, if there are several) grabs the broom and chases that cat out through the **nearest entrance** — then shuts it. The cat is outside. It can come back in through any entrance that's still open.

Scooped!

When **Cuddle** fills, that human picks the cat up. The cat is **Held** (Chapter 9).

AFTER A SHOO! OR A SCOOP

- The cat drops whatever it was carrying, and the human puts it back where it was.
- That meter empties to 0. The other meter stays where it is.
- **Patience drops by 1** (never below 2). The house is getting fed up.
- If a meter fills and no human can see a cat, it stays full: the next cat seen on that side gets it.

Reading the room

Because the meters fill separately, the gang can steer. If Broom is nearly full, be sweet for a while; if Cuddle is nearly full, keep the Charmer out of sight and let the Muscle work. Watch both meters, and remember that Patience only ever goes down.

EXAMPLE

The Okafors' house has Patience 6. Mrs Okafor is in the living room with the box. Velvet distracts her with a slow blink (Sweet, Clean): Cuddle 1. Pip, carrying the box with Biscuit and Mags past Tayo in the hall, rolls a Scrape: Broom 1. Later Mags flops a Sneaky roll in front of Tayo. The meters are level (1 and 1), so the Flop goes on its own meter: Broom +2, now 3. Tayo is a kid, but he only doubles Cuddle steps.

ch-round

CHAPTER 6

A Round in the House

A robbery is played in rounds. In each round every cat gets a turn, and then the house takes one: the humans wander, the dog sniffs about, and the prize gets closer to being eaten, played with or thrown out.

A ROUND

1. **The Prize Clock.** If this round is on the house's Prize Clock, the human puts the prize in its place and stays in that room this round.
2. **Temptation.** The Storyteller may tempt one cat (Chapter 7).
3. **Cats.** Every free cat in the house takes a turn, in any order you like: **one Move** and **one Action**, either way round. Cats outside can come in.
4. **The house.** Noise, then every human's and pet's routine, then anyone holding a cat rolls.

Your turn: a Move and an Action

A Move takes you into the next room through an open way, or in or out through an entrance. Walking is never a roll.

An Action is one roll, or one simple thing. Simple things need no roll when no human can see you: pick something up, put it down, eat a portion, help another cat, hide, or **make a noise** on purpose. Seen, any of them is a roll (Chapter 5).

Opening a closed door is an Action (the house says how hard). Going through an entrance that needs a roll takes your Move *and* your Action.

Noise

A Scrape or a Flop makes noise. So do cat flaps, barking dogs, squawking parrots, and a cat who knocks something over on purpose. At the end of the round, each noise draws the **closest awake human within two rooms** who isn't already in that room. They walk in and stay there for the rest of the round instead of following their routine. Deal with noises in the order they happened; each human answers only one; the Storyteller breaks ties.

Luring. Making a noise on purpose is a good way to pull a human out of the room you want. But if they arrive and find a mess, Broom goes up by 1.

Distract

A Sweet roll aimed at a human who can see you. If it works, that human is **Distracted** until the end of the round: they see nobody, so the rest of the gang can work right under their nose. It adds Cuddle steps as usual. Each time you distract the same human again in the same robbery, it costs a die.

The house's turn

1. **Noise**, as above.
2. **Routines.** The Storyteller rolls a d6 for each other human and pet, reads their routine, and moves them straight to that room. They only see the room they end up in. A human who is **Searching** doesn't follow their routine (Chapter 10).
3. **Discovery.** Anyone who walked into the prize's room and found it disturbed adds +1 Broom — and starts Searching.
4. **Holders** roll to see what happens to the cat they're holding (Chapter 9).

KEEP IT MOVING

Most turns are short: "I go to the kitchen and hide under the table." Let players plan together, but when a round drags, start the house's turn — humans don't wait.

ch-instincts

CHAPTER 7

Instincts

Cats can't help themselves. There is a glass on the edge of the table. There is a box. Something moved. Every cat has two **instincts**: things it's brilliant at, and things it simply cannot walk past.

Knacks

When what you're doing suits one of your instincts, roll **+1 die**. That's your **Knack**. You only ever get one Knack die on a roll, even if both instincts fit.

Temptation

Each room in a house lists its temptations — the cake on the side, a basket of washing, a dangling string — and which instincts they tempt. At the start of each round, the Storyteller may **tempt one cat** who is in a room with a temptation for one of its instincts. (Only one cat per round, however big the gang, and never the same cat with the same thing twice.)

The tempted cat chooses:

- **Give in.** Gain **1 Cattitude**. Your Action this round is the instinct thing, done right away, in that room, before you move. It is never a roll. If you were carrying something, you drop it.
- **Resist.** Spend **1 Cattitude**. If you have none, you must give in.

INSTINCT	KNACK: +1 DIE TO…	TEMPTED BY…	GIVING IN	SEEN?
Curious	open, search, figure things out	a bag, a drawer, something new	You rummage in it. Noise.	+1 Broom
Knocker	knock, push, topple	something on the edge of a table	You knock it off. Noise — and a mess for whoever comes to look.	+1 Broom
Box Sitter	hide	a box, a bag, a basket	You get in. Quiet, and you're hidden.	—
Hunter	pounce, chase, fight	anything that moves	You chase it round the room. Noise.	—
Lap Cat	charm a human	a lap, a sunny spot, a hand to rub	You go for a fuss. A human in the room is Distracted until the round ends. No human? A sunny spot: quiet.	+1 Cuddle
Foodie	find, steal and eat food	food that isn't the prize	You eat it. Quiet.	+1 Broom
Climber	climb, jump, balance	somewhere high	You go up there. Quiet, and you're hidden.	—
Scrapper	face down and fight animals	an animal that stares, barks or hisses	You square up to it. Noise; a dog there turns angry.	+1 Broom

The **Seen?** column is what giving in adds to the Mood if a human sees it. Chasing a fly or climbing a bookcase looks like ordinary cat business; eating the dog's dinner doesn't.

WHY GIVE IN?

Giving in costs your Action and makes trouble, but it pays for the Cattitude that makes your important rolls work. A Lap Cat giving in at the right moment is a free distraction; a Box Sitter giving in is a free hiding place. The Storyteller will pick the worst moment to tempt you. Pick the best moment to say yes.

TEMPTING FAIRLY

Tempt the cat whose temptation makes the best story, but don't tempt the same player every round. If you can't choose, roll for it among the cats who could be tempted.

ch-prize

CHAPTER 8

In, Out, and the Prize

You saw it go in. Now you have to get in after it, get it, and get out again — every one of you — before it's eaten, put away or flattened for the recycling.

Getting in

The robbery starts with every cat **outside**. Each house has three or four **entrances**, and its map lists them: where each leads, how big it is, and what it takes to get through.

- Going through an entrance, in or out, is your **Move**. If the entrance needs a roll (a climb up the drainpipe, a cat flap to jam open), that roll is your **Action** too.
- Cats can split up and use different entrances.
- **The front door** only works while the human is coming in (round 1 in most houses), and only **one** cat gets through before it shuts: slip past their legs (Sneaky, Hard, in view of the human) or say hello (Sweet — they let you in).
- A shut entrance — the window someone closed after a Shoo! — can be opened again from inside (Streetwise, Hard).

Ways through the house

Rooms join by **ways**: doorways, stairs, gaps. A way is **Tight** (Lean cats only, and Small things), **Normal** (any cat; things up to Medium) or **Big** (anything). A closed door has to be opened first: usually Streetwise, Tricky (jump for the handle) or Savage, Hard (shove).

The prize

Before the robbery the Storyteller decides what the human carried in, or rolls a d6: **1–2 delicious, 3–4 fun, 5–6 a box**, then a d6 on that table. The ready-to-run houses in Part Four each have their own.

D6	DELICIOUS	FUN	A BOX
1	a rotisserie chicken (Medium)	a catnip mouse (Small)	a delivery box (Large)
2	a whole salmon (Medium)	a ball of wool (Small)	a shoebox (Medium)
3	a birthday cake (Medium)	a feather wand (Small)	a box of new trainers (Medium)
4	a bag of prawns (Small)	a squeaky ball (Small)	a pizza box, empty (Medium)
5	a pack of ham (Small)	a laser pointer (Small)	a cat bed, still in its box (Large)
6	a tray of sausages (Medium)	a toy bird with a bell (Small)	a box with a new kettle in it (Medium)

WHERE IT GOES

The prize starts in the human's arms. The house's **Prize Clock** says which round it's put down, where, when it's moved, and the round it's **gone** — eaten, put in a drawer, or flattened for the recycling. When the Clock moves it, the human who moves it stays in that room for the round.

If the gang already has the prize when the Clock says to move it, the human goes to fetch it, finds it gone (**+1 Broom**), and starts **Searching** (Chapter 10).

GETTING AT IT

A prize's spot can take several **steps**: up on the counter, then the foil off. Each step needs one roll that works, by any cat in the room. A step done stays done for the whole gang. Getting the prize down from its spot isn't climbing.

TAKING IT

SIZE	WHO CAN CARRY IT	WHERE IT FITS
Small	any one cat, in its mouth	anywhere
Medium	one Chonky cat, or two cats	Normal and Big ways; no climbing
Large	three cats, or two if one is Chonky	Big ways only; no climbing

Each carrier picks it up as its Action; then the carriers move together, using their Moves. **Moving it past a human is a roll**: one carrier leads (Sneaky or Savage) and the others help. A cat with its mouth full can't be Sweet.

EATING IT

Delicious prizes come in **portions**, set by the house per cat in the gang. Eating one is an Action. You can also carry food out instead.

Getting out, and the end

The prize is **gone** at the start of its Clock's last round. **Lights Out** falls at the end of the second round after that: the humans go to bed, and **any cat still inside — held, shut in, or free — is adopted**. The robbery ends at Lights Out, or as soon as no free cat is inside.

OUTCOME	WHEN
Clean Getaway	The prize is eaten or outside, and nobody was left behind.
Messy Getaway	The prize is eaten or outside but someone was left behind — or at least half the food was eaten.
Busted	Anything less.

Gang size

The houses are written for four cats. With **three**, the house's Patience is 1 higher and the prize goes 1 round later. With **five**, it goes 1 round sooner. Food portions already count the cats.

ch-caught

CHAPTER 9

Caught!

"Who's a good kitty? Who's a lovely good kitty? Are you hungry? You can stay here with me." — the end of many a street cat's career

Getting chased out with a broom is undignified, but you can always come back in another way. Getting **picked up** is worse. Humans who pick up cats tend to keep them.

Held

When Cuddle fills, a human picks the cat up. A **Held** cat can't move, and drops anything it was carrying. While the human is holding a cat, they see nobody else and don't follow their routine — so a held cat is, in a way, the best distraction there is.

On its turn a held cat can **wriggle free** (Savage, Tricky; Chonky cats get +1 die). If it works, the cat drops to the floor in that room, seen. Or it can go limp and purr, and let the gang get on with it.

At the end of each round, the human holding a cat rolls a d6:

D6	WHAT THE HUMAN DOES
1–3	Keeps cuddling.
4–5	Carries the cat to the **Den** — the house's spare room or bathroom — and shuts it in, "just until we find your owner".
6	Puts the cat outside: "Go on, home you go."

Shut in

A cat in the Den is **Shut In**; its door stays shut while a cat is inside. A friend in the next room can open it (Streetwise, Tricky — jump for the handle). The cat on its own needs Streetwise, Hard. Once the door is open, the cat is free.

Adopted

Any cat still inside when the robbery ends — held, shut in or free — is adopted. The humans keep it. It gets a name it doesn't like, a bowl with its picture on, and a warm spot by the radiator. For the gang it's a loss; for the cat, honestly, it isn't so bad.

In a one-off robbery, an adopted cat's player can play a resident for the rest of the session if the Storyteller likes — the house cat, perhaps, who isn't keen on the new arrival. In a campaign, read on.

Nine Lives

Every cat has **9 Lives**. They only matter in a campaign (Chapter 13). When a cat is adopted, its player can spend a Life: the cat slips out of a window in the night and is back with the gang by the next robbery. With no Lives left, the cat stays where it is, happily, for ever.

NOBODY GETS HURT

Describe every catch as cartoon slapstick: the broom sweeps, the cat skids out of the door and lands on its feet; the scoop is all "ooh, look at you". The worst thing that can happen is love.

ch-residents

CHAPTER 10

Who Lives There

EVERY HOUSE HAS ITS PEOPLE AND ITS PETS, AND EVERY one of them has a routine. The Storyteller plays them all — fairly, by the dice.

Humans

Each human has an **Attention** of 0, 1 or 2: how hard they are to fool. When a human is watching, their Attention takes dice away from Sneaky and Sweet rolls (only the highest Attention counts if several are watching). Savage rolls ignore it — but Savage never goes unnoticed.

Each human has a **d6 routine**: six results, each "stays put" or a room. At the end of every round the Storyteller rolls for each human who didn't answer a noise, and they go straight to that room. They only see the room they end up in.

TRAITS

TRAIT	WHAT IT DOES
Kid	Loves cats. Doubles Cuddle steps from any roll they see.
Dozes	Each round, on a 1–2 on an extra d6, falls asleep until the end of the next round: sees nothing, hears nothing.
Busy	Too busy cooking (or working) to answer noise. Still sees everything in the room.
Headphones	Doesn't answer noise. Usually a teenager.

SEARCHING

SEARCHING

A human who walks in and finds the prize disturbed — or goes to fetch it and finds it gone — adds +1 Broom and starts **Searching** for the rest of the robbery. At the end of each round, instead of following their routine, a Searching human:

1. stays put if they can see a cat in their room; otherwise
2. steps into a next room where they can see a cat (a room with cats carrying the prize first; the Storyteller picks between others); otherwise
3. follows their routine as usual.

Hidden cats aren't seen, so a Searching human walks right past them.

Pets

Pets have a **rating** of 1 to 3 (how much dice they take away when they're in your way) and a d6 routine like a human's. A routine result of **sniff** means the pet goes one room towards the nearest cat. Pets don't fill the Mood; they make noise, and they get in the way. A pet that is **driven off** hides somewhere for 3 rounds, then comes back to its usual room.

Dog

"Woof. WOOF. Woof woof."

RATING 1–3 **ROUTINE** d6: rooms, stay, sniff

Asleep: Some dogs start asleep. A sleeping dog does nothing until there's noise in its room or the next one; then it wakes and follows its routine.

Bark: An awake dog barks — noise — at the end of any round a cat is in its room. Dogs smell hidden cats.

Charge: A cat that walks into an awake dog's room, or starts its turn there, must leave or deal with the dog before doing anything else.

Beat it: **Savage** drives it off (it hides for 3 rounds). **Sweet** befriends a *soft* dog for the rest of the robbery. **Sneaky** slips past it for this turn. A Flop: the dog chases you into the next room, barking.

House cat

"This is MY kitchen."

RATING 1–3 **ROUTINE** stays in its room

Guard: Guards one room. A gang cat in that room must leave or deal with it before doing anything else. It isn't fooled by hiding spots.

Beat it: As a dog: Savage drives it off, Sweet befriends a soft one, Sneaky slips past for this turn.

Parrot

"PRETTY BOY! CAT! CAT!"

RATING — **ROUTINE** never moves

Squawk: At the end of any round it saw a cat that wasn't hidden, it squawks: noise in its room.

Beat it: Throw a cloth over its cage (Streetwise, Tricky): it goes quiet for the rest of the robbery.

Robot vacuum

"Bweep."

RATING — **ROUTINE** one room each round, at random

Wanders: Goes into a random next room at the end of each round. It tempts Hunters in whatever room it's in.

Ride it: A cat can hop on (a simple Action): it moves with the vacuum and counts as hidden while it rides. Hopping off is free.

PART THREE

Running the House

For the Storyteller: how to play the humans, the pets and the Prize Clock — and how to build a house of your own.

part-storyteller

ch-storyteller

CHAPTER 11

The Storyteller

You are the house. You are the grown-up with the chicken, the kid who wants a kitten, the dog who has never once caught anything, and the clock on the wall. You don't try to beat the gang — the dice and the routines do that. Your job is to make the house feel alive and fair.

Three promises

- **Play the routines straight.** Roll every human's and pet's routine in the open and do what the die says. The players should be able to plan around the house, and be surprised by it.
- **Say the stakes before the roll.** "That's Tricky, and Mr Pell is watching, so it fills Broom if he sees it." Nobody should be surprised by the rules.
- **Make it funny, never cruel.** Cats skid, slide, sneeze into the flour. Humans say "aww" and "HEY!". Nobody gets hurt (Chapter 9).

Before you start

1. Pick a house from Part Four, or make one (Chapter 12). Read its page and keep its tracker in front of you.
2. Set out the tracker: Patience (adjusted for gang size), the Mood meters at 0, the Prize Clock.
3. Read the start of the house aloud: the street, the house, the human going in with the prize.
4. Show the players the map's **ways in**. They choose where each cat goes.

EVERY ROUND, IN ORDER

1. **Prize Clock.** Does the prize get put down or moved this round? Its human goes there and stays. (Gang already has it? The human goes to fetch it, finds it gone: +1 Broom, and they start Searching.) Is it gone this round?
2. **Tempt** one cat, or nobody.
3. **Cats act.** For each roll: who can see it? What does it need? Then update the meters.
4. **Noise:** list this round's noises in order; move the closest human within two rooms (not already there) to each. Mess found: +1 Broom.
5. **Routines:** roll for every other human and pet. Searching humans hunt instead.
6. **Discovery:** anyone who walked in on the prize disturbed: +1 Broom, and Searching.
7. **Holders** roll.
8. Is it Lights Out? Is any free cat still inside?

Calling the roll

When a player says what their cat does, decide three things: **which approach** (they usually tell you), **how hard** (plain, Tricky or Hard — the house lists the hard bits), and **who can see it**. Then let them count their dice.

IT'S…	FOR EXAMPLE
Plain	a low chair, a door already ajar, a bag left open
Tricky (–1)	a kitchen counter, a lever handle, a stiff window, foil on a plate
Hard (–2)	the top of the fridge, a round doorknob, a drainpipe, a microchip cat flap

When the meters fill

Make Shoo! and Scooped! big moments. Stop, describe it, then do the bookkeeping: drop the prize back in its place, empty the meter, and lower Patience by 1 out loud — the players should feel the house running out of patience.

Young players

For players around eight: let them count their own dice, read the highest die together, and use tokens for Cattitude. Keep the map on the table and the cats on it as counters. Skip the distraction and lure details in the first robbery; they'll find them by themselves.

HOW HARD ARE THE HOUSES?

We played each house thousands of times with a computer gang that follows the rules exactly. With four sensible players, the gang gets the prize about 9 times in 10 at an Easy house, 3 times in 4 at a Standard house, and a bit more than half the time at a Hard house. At a Hard house, one robbery in six ends with a cat adopted.

ch-making-a-house

CHAPTER 12

Making a House

EVERY HOUSE ON THE STREET HAS A STORY: WHO LIVES there, what they just brought home, and why they left the kitchen window open. Here is how to build one that plays well.

A HOUSE NEEDS

- **5 to 8 rooms**, with a map. Each room: its name, any hiding spots that are missing, and one or two temptations (with the instinct they tempt).
- **Ways** between rooms: their size, and any closed doors with how hard they are to open.
- **3 or 4 entrances** — never fewer than two — each with its room, size and what it takes. At least one should need no climbing, so a Medium or Large prize can get out.
- **A Den**: a room with a door, away from the entrances.
- **1 to 4 humans**, each with Attention, a trait if any, a start room and a d6 routine.
- **0 to 2 pets**, each with a rating, a start room and a d6 routine.
- **The prize**: what it is, its size, portions if it's food, and the **Prize Clock** — when it's put down, where, how many steps to get at it, when it moves, and the round it's gone.
- **Patience.**

Portions

A Small food is **1 portion per cat**. A Medium food is **1 per cat, plus 1 or 2**. A cake or something big is **2 per cat**.

How hard?

These are the knobs that matter most, from the simulations behind the houses in Part Four:

KNOB	EASIER	HARDER
Patience	5–6	3
Prize Clock	gone on round 10–12	gone on round 7–8
The prize	food (eaten where it is)	a Large thing that has to go out through one Big way
Humans near the prize	one human who wanders	a busy cook who never leaves, or three or more people
Attention	0–1	2
Pets	a soft dog, asleep	a rating-3 dog that roams the prize's rooms

KNOB	EASIER	HARDER
Entrances	a free way in next to the prize	only climbs and microchip flaps

Our five houses use: **Easy** — Patience 4, one human, a soft dog, food, gone on round 7. **Standard** — Patience 6, two humans and a pet, a thing to carry out, gone on round 11. **Hard** — Patience 3, several watchful humans or a busy cook and a big dog, food, gone on round 8–10.

Routines that make a house play

- Give every room at least one result on *some* routine. A room nobody ever visits becomes a safe place to wait, and waiting is boring.
- Put the prize's room on the routine of the human who owns it at least twice.
- "Stays put" on 1–3 makes a human easy to plan around; on 1–2 they wander more.

TEST IT

Before the night, walk one cat round the map: in through each entrance, to the prize, and out again with it. Check every way you need is big enough for the prize, and that the Den has a door.

ch-the-block

CHAPTER 13

The Block

One robbery makes a great evening. A street full of houses makes a campaign: the gang gets a name, a reputation, and a list of humans who now lock their windows.

Playing a campaign

Each session is one robbery at one house on the Block. Draw a simple map of the street, and add houses as the gang hears about them: the five in Part Four, and any you make.

What carries over

THING	BETWEEN ROBBERIES
Cattitude	Back to 2 each robbery.
Lives	Carry over. Spend one when a cat is adopted to have it escape before the next robbery.
Rep	The gang gets **1 Rep** for every Clean Getaway.
Houses	A house the gang has robbed before starts with **Patience 1 lower** (never below 2). They remember.

Rep

At **3, 6 and 9 Rep**, every cat in the gang raises one approach by 1 (never above 4). A cat who joins later starts with as many raises as the gang has had.

Adopted cats

A cat adopted with no Lives to spend leaves the gang, and its player makes a new cat. The old one isn't gone: it lives somewhere on the Block now. One day the gang may rob that very house — and meet a familiar face by the radiator, who might help them, or might not.

A cat's last Life

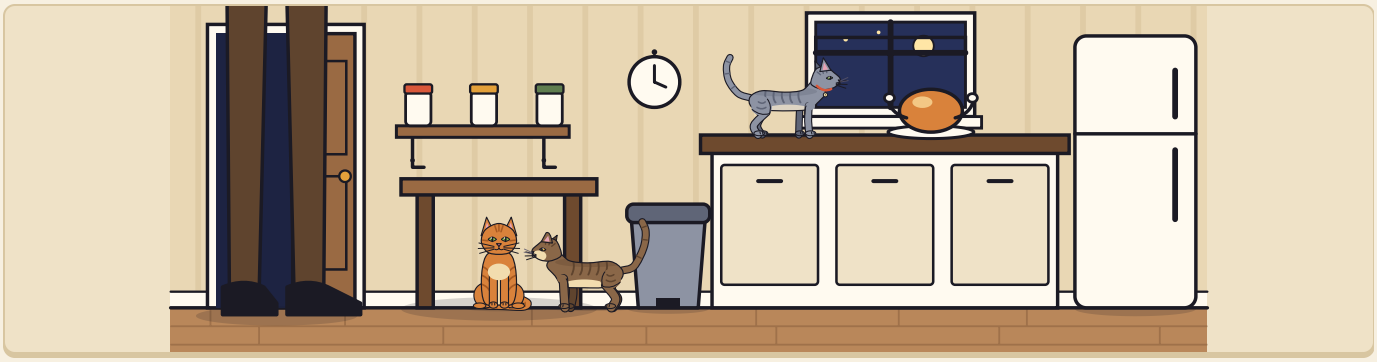
When a cat spends its ninth Life, it has nothing left to spend: the next time it's adopted, it stays. Most players find their cat a very happy ending there.

PART FOUR

Five Houses

Ready to rob tonight: one easy, two standard, two hard.

part-houses



CHAPTER 14

The Chicken at Number 12

The best first robbery: one man, one old dog, one chicken.

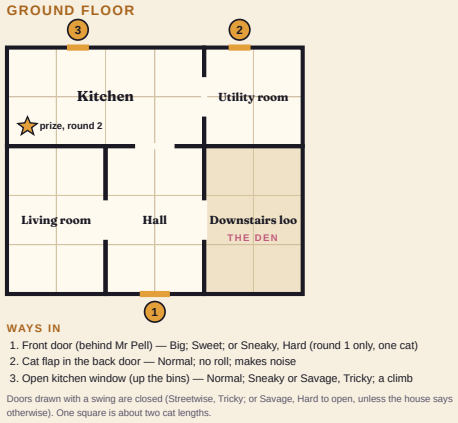
READ THIS ALOUD

It's a quarter to seven and the street smells of rain. Mr Pell comes up the path with a shopping bag, and out of the top of it pokes a rotisserie chicken, still warm, wrapped in foil. He fumbles for his key. The door opens. From the kitchen comes the thump-thump of his old dog Pudding's tail. The door begins to close…

AT A GLANCE

Difficulty Easy · **Patience** 4 · **The prize** rotisserie chicken (Medium, portions: 1 per cat + 1) · **Gone** at the start of round 7 · **Den** Downstairs loo

Who lives here Mr Pell, Pudding



The Chicken at Number 12: the floor plan and the ways in.

NUMBER 12 IS A SMALL TERRACED HOUSE: HALL, FRONT room, kitchen at the back with a utility room off it, and a downstairs loo. Mr Pell lives alone with Pudding, a soft old spaniel who would rather be fed than fight. He'll put the chicken on the kitchen counter in its foil and potter about until he eats it.

The Prize Clock

WHEN	THE PRIZE
Start of round 2	Mr Pell puts it in the kitchen and stays there this round. Step 1: Sneaky or Savage, Tricky; then step 2: Streetwise or Savage, Tricky.
Start of round 7	Gone — if the gang hasn't got it.
End of round 9	Lights Out: any cat still inside is adopted.

The rooms

ROOM	TEMPTS	NOTES
Hall	Curious	—
Living room	Box Sitter, Lap Cat, Knocker	—
Kitchen	Foodie, Knocker, Climber	door to the utility room (Streetwise, Tricky; or Savage, Hard)
Utility room	Hunter, Curious	door to the kitchen (Streetwise, Tricky; or Savage, Hard)
Downstairs loo	—	**the Den**

The **cat flap** clacks every time a cat uses it. The **kitchen window** is open a crack above the sink: up the bins and in. The utility room door to the kitchen is shut; it has a lever handle.

Who lives here

Mr Pell
Grown-up

ATTENTION 1 **STARTS IN** Hall

Routine (d6): 1–2 stays put; 3–4 Kitchen; 5–6 Living room.

Pudding
Dog

RATING 2 **STARTS IN** Kitchen

Routine (d6): 1–2 stays put; 3 Living room; 4 Kitchen; 5 Hall; 6 sniffs one room toward the nearest cat.

Dog: Barks, charges and smells hidden cats (Chapter 10). **Soft:** Sweet can befriend it.

How it plays

- **The quick way** is the kitchen window: it's a climb, but it puts you next to the chicken.
- **The quiet way** is through the cat flap — but it clacks, and then there's the utility door to open.
- Mr Pell spends a lot of time in the kitchen. A Charmer who keeps him busy, or a cat who lures him to the front room, is worth a lot. Pudding is easy to befriend.
- The chicken is gone at the start of round 7. That's quick: don't dawdle.

FIRST TIME RUNNING THE GAME?

Run Number 12. Roll Mr Pell's routine every round, out loud. When the chicken is put down, describe the foil crackling. When the first cat flops in front of Mr Pell, have him say "Oi!" and fill Broom by 2 — the players learn the Mood in one go.

ch-okafor-box

CHAPTER 15

The Okafors' Big Box

It doesn't matter what's in it. It's a box.

READ THIS ALOUD

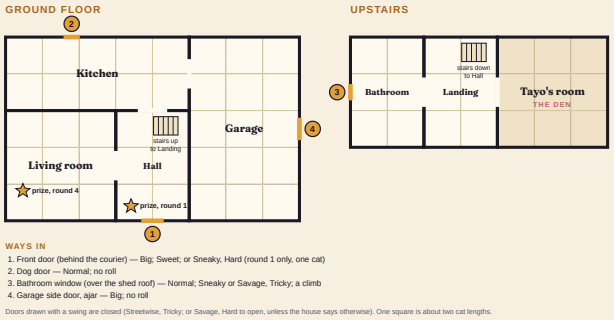
A van stops outside Number 31. The courier staggers up the path with the biggest box any of you have ever seen. Mrs Okafor signs for it in the doorway while her son Tayo bounces behind her. She drags it into the hall. Somewhere in the kitchen a dog barks once, sleepily, and stops.

AT A GLANCE

Difficulty Standard · **Patience** 6 · **The prize** big delivery box (Large) · **Gone** at the start of round 11 · **Den** Tayo's room

Who lives here Mrs Okafor, Tayo, Noodle

The Okafors' house has a hall, a living room, a long kitchen with a dog door, and a garage with its side door left ajar. Upstairs are the bathroom, the landing and Tayo's room. Mrs Okafor will unpack the box in the living room, and then she'll flatten it for the recycling. The gang wants it before that — the whole thing, out of the house.



The Okafors' Big Box: the floor plan and the ways in.

The Prize Clock

WHEN	THE PRIZE
Start of round 1	Mrs Okafor puts it in the hall and stays there this round. No roll to get at it.
Start of round 5	Mrs Okafor puts it in the living room and stays there this round. No roll to get at it.
Start of round 11	Gone — if the gang hasn't got it.
End of round 13	Lights Out: any cat still inside is adopted.

The rooms

ROOM	TEMPTS	NOTES
Hall	Box Sitter	—
Living room	Lap Cat, Hunter, Knocker	—
Kitchen	Foodie, Curious	—
Garage	Hunter, Climber	—
Landing	Climber	—
Bathroom	—	—
Tayo's room	Box Sitter	**the Den**

The box is **Large**: it takes three cats to move (or two with a Chonky one), and it only fits through Big ways. The only Big way out after round 1 is the **garage side door**, through the kitchen.

Who lives here

Mrs Okafor
Grown-up

ATTENTION 1 **STARTS IN** Hall

Routine (d6): 1–3 stays put; 4 Kitchen; 5–6 Living room.

Tayo
Kid

ATTENTION 1 **STARTS IN** Living room

Routine (d6): 1–2 stays put; 3–4 Tayo's room; 5 Living room; 6 Kitchen.

Kid: Doubles Cuddle steps from any roll they see.

Noodle
Dog

RATING 2 **STARTS IN** Kitchen, asleep

Routine (d6): 1–2 stays put; 3 Hall; 4 Garage; 5 Living room; 6 sniffs one room toward the nearest cat.

Dog: Barks, charges and smells hidden cats (Chapter 10). **Soft:** Sweet can befriend it.

How it plays

- This is a carrying job. Get three cats onto the box, then move it room by room. Every room with a human in it is a roll.
- Waiting it out won't work for long: at the start of round 5 Mrs Okafor comes for the box, and if it isn't where she left it, she starts **Searching**.
- Tayo is a kid: Sweet rolls he sees fill Cuddle twice as fast. Distract his mum, not him.
- Noodle sleeps in the kitchen, right on the way out. Don't wake him — or befriend him; he's soft.
- If someone Shoos a cat out through the garage, the side door shuts — and that's the box's only way out. Reopen it from inside (Streetwise, Hard).

ch-wendell-mouse

CHAPTER 16

Grandpa Wendell's Catnip Mouse

"It's for Duchess. She deserves nice things."

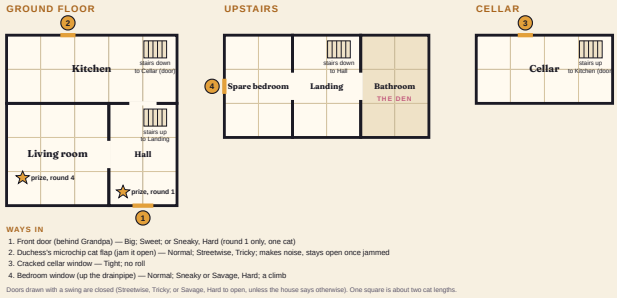
READ THIS ALOUD

Grandpa Wendell comes home from the pet shop with a paper bag, and through the paper you can smell it: catnip. A whole catnip mouse, red felt, with a string tail. His daughter June is in the kitchen putting the kettle on. In the front window, a large fluffy cat called Duchess watches you all with deep contempt.

AT A GLANCE

Difficulty Standard · **Patience** 6 · **The prize** catnip mouse (Small) · **Gone** at the start of round 11 · **Den** Bathroom

Who lives here Grandpa Wendell, June, Duchess, The robot vacuum



Grandpa Wendell's Catnip Mouse: the floor plan and the ways in.

GRANDPA WENDELL'S HOUSE HAS A HALL, A FRONT room where Duchess rules, a kitchen with Duchess's microchip cat flap, a cellar under the kitchen with a cracked window, and upstairs a spare bedroom, a landing and the bathroom. The mouse is small — one cat can carry it — but it has to get out of the house, and Duchess will want it too.

The Prize Clock

WHEN	THE PRIZE
Start of round 1	Grandpa Wendell puts it in the hall and stays there this round. Step 1: Streetwise or Sneaky, Tricky.
Start of round 4	Grandpa Wendell puts it in the living room and stays there this round. No roll to get at it.
Start of round 11	Gone — if the gang hasn't got it.
End of round 13	Lights Out: any cat still inside is adopted.

The rooms

ROOM	TEMPTS	NOTES
Hall	Curious	—
Living room	Hunter, Lap Cat, Box Sitter	—
Kitchen	Foodie, Knocker	door to the cellar (Streetwise, Tricky; or Savage, Hard)
Cellar	Hunter, Curious	door to the kitchen (Streetwise, Tricky; or Savage, Hard)
Landing	—	—
Spare bedroom	Climber, Box Sitter	—
Bathroom	Box Sitter	**the Den**

Duchess's **cat flap** only opens for her microchip; jam it (Streetwise, Tricky) and it stays open for everyone. The **cellar window** is Tight: Lean cats only. The **bedroom window** is up the drainpipe: Hard.

Who lives here

Grandpa Wendell
Grandparent

ATTENTION 0 **STARTS IN** Hall

Routine (d6): 1–4 stays put; 5 Living room; 6 Kitchen.

Dozes: Each round on a 1–2 (extra d6), asleep until the end of the next round.

June
Grown-up

ATTENTION 1 **STARTS IN** Kitchen

Routine (d6): 1–3 stays put; 4 Living room; 5 Hall; 6 Kitchen.

Duchess
House cat

RATING 2 **GUARDS** Living room

House cat: Guards its room (Chapter 10). **Soft:** Sweet can befriend her.

The robot vacuum
Robot vacuum

STARTS IN Living room **GOES** Living room, Hall, Kitchen

Vacuum: Wanders one room a round; tempts Hunters; can be ridden (Chapter 10).

How it plays

- Grab the mouse from the shopping bag in the hall before Grandpa gives it to Duchess at the start of round 4. After that you have to get past her.
- Grandpa dozes. A sleeping Grandpa sees nothing — perfect for a quick snatch.
- The robot vacuum tempts Hunters wherever it goes — and can be ridden.
- Getting out is the hard part: plan the exit before you grab the mouse.

ch-birthday-cake

CHAPTER 17

The Birthday Cake

Happy birthday, Mia. Sorry about the cake.

READ THIS ALOUD

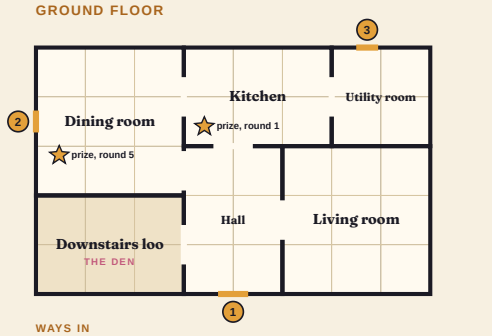
There are balloons on the gate of Number 5 and music inside. Dad carries a cake in from the car and straight through to the kitchen — chocolate, three layers, under a plastic cover — and the guests are still arriving. In the dining room, a grey parrot shouts "PARTY!" at nobody. Aunt Rosalind, who notices everything, is already sitting in the best chair.

AT A GLANCE

Difficulty Hard · **Patience** 3 · **The prize** birthday cake (Medium, portions: 2 per cat) · **Gone** at the start of round 8 · **Den** Downstairs loo

Who lives here Dad, Aunt Rosalind, Mia, Leo, Captain the parrot

A BIRTHDAY PARTY: THE HOUSE IS FULL OF PEOPLE. DAD is in the kitchen with the cake, Aunt Rosalind holds court in the dining room, and Mia and her brother Leo run everywhere. The patio door is open for the guests. At the start of round 5 the cake goes to the dining-room table for the candles, and it will be cut and served at the start of round 8.



WAYS IN

1. Front door (guests arriving) — Big; Sweet; or Sneaky, Hard (rounds 1–2 only, one cat)
2. Patio door, ajar — Big; no roll
3. Utility window (up the water butt) — Normal; Sneaky or Savage, Tricky; a climb

Doors drawn with a swing are closed (Streetwise, Tricky; or Savage, Hard to open, unless the house says otherwise). One square is about two cat lengths.

The Birthday Cake: the floor plan and the ways in.

The Prize Clock

WHEN	THE PRIZE
Start of round 1	Dad puts it in the kitchen and stays there this round. Step 1: Sneaky or Savage, Tricky; then step 2: Streetwise or Savage, Tricky.
Start of round 5	Dad puts it in the dining room and stays there this round. Step 1: Sneaky or Savage, Tricky.
Start of round 8	Gone — if the gang hasn't got it.
End of round 10	Lights Out: any cat still inside is adopted.

The rooms

ROOM	TEMPTS	NOTES
Hall	Curious, Box Sitter	—
Kitchen	Foodie, Knocker	—
Dining room	Hunter, Climber	—
Living room	Hunter, Box Sitter, Lap Cat	—
Utility room	Curious	—
Downstairs loo	—	**the Den**

The **front door** keeps opening for guests, so it works in rounds 1 and 2. The **patio door** is open and needs no roll — but it opens into the dining room, where Aunt Rosalind and Captain are.

Who lives here

Dad
Grown-up

ATTENTION 1 **STARTS IN** Kitchen

Routine (d6): 1–3 stays put; 4 Dining room; 5 Hall; 6 Living room.

Aunt Rosalind
Grown-up

ATTENTION 2 **STARTS IN** Dining room

Routine (d6): 1–4 stays put; 5 Kitchen; 6 Living room.

Mia
Kid

ATTENTION 1 **STARTS IN** Living room

Routine (d6): 1–2 stays put; 3 Dining room; 4 Hall; 5 Kitchen; 6 Living room.

Kid: Doubles Cuddle steps from any roll they see.

Leo
Kid

ATTENTION 1 **STARTS IN** Living room

Routine (d6): 1–2 stays put; 3–4 Dining room; 5 Hall; 6 Living room.

Kid: Doubles Cuddle steps from any roll they see.

Captain the parrot
Parrot

LIVES IN Dining room

Parrot: Squawks at cats it can see; cover the cage (Streetwise, Tricky) to quiet it (Chapter 10).

How it plays

- There are four humans and a parrot. You can't distract them all; work out who will be where.
- Aunt Rosalind has Attention 2: Sneaky and Sweet are hard under her nose.
- Two kids double every Cuddle step. A Charmer here gets scooped fast.
- Eating half the cake is a Messy Getaway — and at this house that's a good night.

ch-marchetti-salmon

CHAPTER 18

Chef Marchetti's Salmon

The best fish on the street, in the hardest kitchen on the street.

READ THIS ALOUD

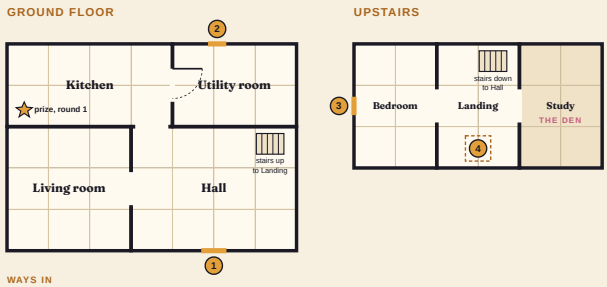
Chef Marchetti carries a whole salmon past Sam at the front door and straight through to her kitchen like a trophy, wrapped in paper from the fish market. From the utility room comes a deep, slow woof, and then the claws of a very big dog on a tiled floor. The kitchen lights go on, and they stay on.

AT A GLANCE

Difficulty Hard · **Patience** 3 · **The prize** whole salmon (Medium, portions: 1 per cat + 2) · **Gone** at the start of round 10 · **Den** Study

Who lives here Chef Marchetti, Sam, Brutus, The robot vacuum

Chef Marchetti cooks for a living, and she never leaves her kitchen while there's a fish on the island. Her partner Sam wanders the house. Their dog Brutus is enormous and not the least bit soft. Upstairs there's a balcony door up the tree, a skylight propped open, a bedroom and a study.



WAYS IN

1. Front door (behind Sam) — Big; Sweet; or Sneaky, Hard (round 1 only, one cat)
2. Brutus's dog door — Normal; no roll
3. Balcony door (up the tree) — Normal; Sneaky or Savage, Hard; a climb
4. Skylight, propped open — Tight; Sneaky or Savage, Tricky; a climb

Doors drawn with a swing are closed (Streetwise, Tricky; or Savage, Hard to open, unless the house says otherwise). One square is about two cat lengths.

Chef Marchetti's Salmon: the floor plan and the ways in.

The Prize Clock

WHEN	THE PRIZE
Start of round 1	Chef Marchetti puts it in the kitchen and stays there this round. Step 1: Sneaky or Savage, Tricky; then step 2: Streetwise or Savage, Tricky.
Start of round 10	Gone — if the gang hasn't got it.
End of round 12	Lights Out: any cat still inside is adopted.

The rooms

ROOM	TEMPTS	NOTES
Hall	—	—
Kitchen	Foodie, Knocker, Hunter	door to the utility room (Streetwise or Savage, Hard)
Living room	Lap Cat, Box Sitter	—
Utility room	Foodie	door to the kitchen (Streetwise or Savage, Hard)
Landing	—	—
Bedroom	Box Sitter	—
Study	Climber, Curious	**the Den**

Brutus's **dog door** leads into the utility room, which is Brutus's room. The **skylight** is Tight and a climb. The **balcony door** is Hard, up the tree.

Who lives here

Chef Marchetti
Grown-up

ATTENTION 2 **STARTS IN** Kitchen

Routine (d6): 1–5 stays put; 6 Hall.

Busy: Cooking: never answers noise.

Sam
Grown-up

ATTENTION 1 **STARTS IN** Hall

Routine (d6): 1–2 stays put; 3–4 Living room; 5 Kitchen; 6 Study.

Brutus
Dog

RATING 3 **STARTS IN** Utility room

Routine (d6): 1 stays put; 2 Kitchen; 3 Hall; 4 Living room; 5–6 sniffs one room toward the nearest cat.

Dog: Barks, charges and smells hidden cats (Chapter 10). Not soft: Sweet won't work on it.

The robot vacuum
Robot vacuum

STARTS IN Living room **GOES** Living room, Hall

Vacuum: Wanders one room a round; tempts Hunters; can be ridden (Chapter 10).

How it plays

- Chef Marchetti is **busy**: no noise will lure her out of the kitchen. She has Attention 2. You will have to work under her nose — or distract her, which gets harder every time.
- Brutus can't be befriended. Drive him off (rating 3: bring your Muscle) or stay out of his way.
- The way in from upstairs is long but quiet.

Cat Sheet

Ratings 3, 2, 1, 1 · two instincts · Cattitude 2 each robbery (max 5) · 9 Lives

Street name _____ **Player** _____

Coat _____ **Mark** _____ **Eyes** _____

Body Lean ☐ Chonky ☐ **Quirk** _____

SNEAKY	SWEET	SAVAGE	STREETWISE

INSTINCT	KNACK: +1 DIE TO…	INSTINCT	KNACK: +1 DIE TO…

Cattitude ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ **Lives** ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

Gang _____ **Rep** _____ **Raises taken** _____

Notes _____

Roll: approach + Knack (+1) + helpers (+1 each, max 2) + Cattitude (+1), max 5; then –1 Tricky, –2 Hard, –pet rating, –Attention (Sneaky/Sweet, when watched). Highest die: 1–3 Flop · 4–5 Scrape · 6 Clean · two 6s Purrfect. **Push:** reroll the non-6s for 1 Cattitude or 1 Mood step.

House Tracker

For the Storyteller · one per robbery

House _____ **Cats** _____ **Patience** _____

BROOM	CUDDLE
○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

Patience after each Shoo! or Scoop _____

ROUND	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13
Prize Clock													

HUMAN / PET	ROOM NOW	SEARCHING?	DISTRACTED THIS ROBBERY	HOLDING

ENTRANCE	OPEN / SHUT	ENTRANCE	OPEN / SHUT

Prize: steps done _____ **Portions left** _____ **Where** _____

Each round: Prize Clock → tempt one cat → cats act → noise (closest human within 2 rooms, not already there; mess +1 Broom) → routines (Searching humans hunt) → walked in on the prize disturbed: +1 Broom and Searching → holders roll. Lights Out: end of the 2nd round after the prize is gone.

Quick Reference

Everything you need at the table

HIGHEST DIE	RESULT
1–3	**Flop**: it doesn't work; noise; seen = 2 steps on the fuller meter
4–5	**Scrape**: it works; noise; seen = 1 step
6	**Clean**: it works; seen = 1 step (Sneaky: none)
Two 6s	**Purrfect**: it works; no step; +1 Cattitude

APPROACH	FILLS	USE IT TO…
Sneaky	Broom	hide, slip past, do it unnoticed (Attention takes dice)
Sweet	Cuddle	distract, persuade, befriend, be let in or out (Attention takes dice)
Savage	Broom	shove, bolt, drive off a pet, wriggle free, just do it
Streetwise	Broom	doors, latches, bags, flaps, cover the parrot

WHEN A METER FILLS	WHAT HAPPENS
Broom — Shoo!	Chased out of the nearest entrance, which is shut. Drop what you carry. Meter to 0, Patience –1.
Cuddle — Scooped!	Held. Drop what you carry. Meter to 0, Patience –1. Holder's d6: 1–3 cuddles, 4–5 the Den, 6 outside.

CATTITUDE	SIZE	CARRIED BY
+1: give in, Purrfect	Small	any one cat
–1: a die, a Push, resist	Medium	a Chonky cat, or two cats; no climbing
Start 2, max 5	Large	three cats, or two with a Chonky; Big ways

Clean Getaway: prize got, nobody left behind · **Messy**: got it but someone was left, or half the food eaten · **Busted**: less. Any cat inside at Lights Out is adopted.

You saw it go in. A chicken. A cake. A box.

You're a gang of street cats, and there is something in that house you want very, very badly. Slip in through the cat flap, charm the grandad, scare off the dog — but don't get caught. Humans don't mind cats. They mind cats who do things. Push it too far and out comes the broom. Be too sweet and somebody picks you up and keeps you for ever.

For 3 to 5 players and a Storyteller, ages 8 and up, about two hours a robbery. Five houses ready to play, a ready-made gang, and rules to build your own street.



Being seen isn't being caught. Being seen doing something is.

CAT BURGLARS · VERSION 0.5